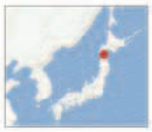
JAPANESE NAVAL MIGHT

THE JAPANESE IMPERIAL NAVY started its life as an ad-hoc force of mostly wooden steam warships assembled to fight the civil conflict known as the Boshin War, in which Emperor Meiji triumphed over Tokugawa loyalists in 1868-69. Over the next two decades Japan founded a modern navy complete with organizational structures copied from the British and the latest styles of warship from European shipyards. The Chinese had also been modernizing their navy and, although European observers were sceptical about the ability of either force, they were inclined to see China as the stronger naval power. In July 1894 a small-scale naval clash at Asan brought China and Japan to open war—as well as causing a diplomatic row with Britain over the Japanese sinking of a British-crewed ship carrying Chinese troops. The subsequent Japanese naval victories at the Yalu River and Weihaiwei revealed the gulf between an Asian power that was successfully modernizing and one that was not. At the end of the war Russia refused to allow Japan to take the Liaodung Peninsula and Port Arthur, which China had agreed to cede, sowing the seeds for the Russo-Japanese War of 1904-05.

BOSHIN WAR

HAKODATE BAY



Date May 4–10, 1869
Forces Meiji: 8 ships; Tokugawa: 5 ships
Losses Meiji: 1 ship; Tokugawa: 2 ships destroyed, 3 captured

Location Hakodate Bay, Hokkaido, Japan

In 1868–69 forces loyal to the Tokugawa shogunate fought to resist the transfer of power to supporters of the Emperor Meiji. An Imperial Japanese Navy was hastily assembled, centered on the French-built ironclad *Kotetsu*. When Imperial forces attacked the last Tokugawa stronghold at Hakodate, the Tokugawa warships failed to prevent troops from landingand were worsted in a series of actions. The Tokugawa schooner *Banryu* succeded in sinking the Imperial ship *Choyo*, but later herself sank. Their steamer *Kaiten* was also disabled. The Tokugawa rebellion collapsed after this naval defeat.



Portable telescope
A lacquered Japanese telescope dating from the time of the First Sino-Japanese War.

FIRST SINO-JAPANESE WAR

YALU RIVER



Date September 17, 1894
Forces Japanese: 10 protected cruisers, 2 other ships; Chinese: 2 battleships, 10 cruisers, 2 other ships
Losses Japanese: none; Chinese: 5 ships

Location Off mouth of Yalu River, Yellow Sea

The first major battle fought by the Imperial Japanese Navy occurred when Admiral Sukeyuki Ito led a fleet on a sweep through Korea Bay, hoping to interrupt Chinese troop landings at the Yalu River, which marks the border between Korea and China. The troop landings were being covered by the Chinese Beiyang Fleet under Admiral Ting Ju ch'ang. The two fleets sighted each other at 11:40 a.m. on the morning of September 17, 1894. They were of roughly equal strength. The Chinese had the most powerful vessels present, two German-built armored turret ships *Ting Yuen* and *Chen Yuen*, which carried 12-in Krupp guns. But the Japanese cruisers were on average larger and faster than their Chinese opposite numbers. The two fleets steamed toward one another through the morning, the Japanese in line-ahead formation and the Chinese in two lines abreast.

Japanese naval firepower
Exotically attired Chinese sailors come under fire from Japanese warships in this fanciful French print showing the Japanese victory at Yalu River.

FIRST SINO-JAPANESE WAR

ASAN



Date July 25, 1894
Forces Japanese: 3 cruisers; Chinese: 1 cruiser, 2 gunboats
Losses Japanese: none; Chinese: 1 gunboat and 1 transport sunk, 1 gunboat captured

Location Off Asan, Korea

In July 1894 Japan and China both had troops in Korea. The Japanese protected cruisers *Yoshino*, *Akitsushima*, and *Naniwa* were blockading Chinese forces at Asan, south of Seoul. At 7:00 a.m. on July 25 the Chinese cruiser *Kwang-yi* and the gunboat *Tsi-yuen* steamed out of Asan Bay toward the Japanese ships. The Japanese opened fire: *Kwang-yi* was damaged and forced back into the bay; the gunboat ran onto rocks and exploded. *Kowshing*, a Chinese troop transport flying the British flag, arrived, accompanied by a gunboat. The gunboat surrendered, but the Chinese soldiers refused to allow *Kowshing*'s British captain to follow suit. The cruiser *Naniwa* sank the troop transport with heavy loss of life.

JAPANESE TRIUMPH

The battle that followed was confused and brutal. The Japanese steamed down both sides of the Chinese formation, pumping shells into the enemy ships. The Chinese armored cruiser *Ting Yuen* rolled over and sank; several other Chinese ships were ravaged by fire, apparently rendered vulnerable by decorative woodwork and layers of flammable paint. Chinese gunnery proved inferior, as did the quality of their munitions, although they had their successes—Admiral Ito's flagship *Matsushima*, for example, was damaged by an explosion when a shell ignited ammunition on board. In five hours' fighting, some ships were hit several hundred times. With five ships sunk, by nightfall the Chinese lay at the mercy of their enemies. But, exhausted and running out of ammunition, Admiral Ito withdrew his fleet short of total victory. The Chinese suffered some 850 men killed and had 500 wounded; Japanese losses numbered 90 killed, about 200 wounded, and not a single Japanese ship was destroyed.



WEAPONS AND TECHNOLOGY

TORPEDOES

The torpedo began life as a static mine. In the second half of the 19th century navies were seeking methods of moving a mine to strike a ship's hull. This led to the spar torpedo, a mine on a long pole projecting from the front of an attack craft, and the Brennan torpedo, a mine controlled by wires from shore. The first effective self-propelled torpedo was invented in the 1860s by Robert Whitehead, a British engineer working on a commission for the Austrian navy. The Whitehead torpedo had a propeller driven by compressed air and used a pressure gauge attached to horizontal rudders to keep a constant depth. Self-propelled torpedoes were unreliable for many decades—most of those fired in the Russo-Japanese war of 1904–05, for example, failed for one reason or another—but their potential was quickly recognized, leading to the development of purpose-built torpedo boats and of torpedo-boat destroyers to counter them.

Whitehead torpedo
The first effective self-propelled torpedo, the Whitehead had a range of over 980 ft (300 m).

